ECOSPHERE
AN ESA OPEN ACCESS JOURNAL

Editor-in-Chief: Sunshine Van Bael
Online ISSN: 2150-8925
Print ISSN: 2150-8925



Latest issue
Volume 17, Issue 8
August 2026

Ecosphere Author Guidelines

Revised April 2026

- General Information
- Subject Tracks and Submission Types
  - Subject Tracks
    - Agroecosystems
    - Animal Ecology
    - Climate Ecology
    - Coastal and Marine Ecology
    - Disease Ecology
    - Eco-Education
    - Ecology of Critical Zones
    - Ecosphere Naturalist
    - Emerging Technologies
    - Freshwater Ecology
    - Macrosystems Ecology
    - Methods, Tools, and Technologies
    - Microbial Ecology
    - Socio-Ecological Systems
    - Vegetation Ecology
  - Submission Types
    - Article
    - Comment
    - Reply
    - Concepts & Theory
    - Innovative Viewpoints
    - Synthesis & Integration
    - Special Features
- Authorship List and Roles
  - Author List
  - Authors of Supporting Information

Sign up for email alerts

Enter your email to receive alerts when new articles and issues are published.

Email address

Enter email

Continue

Journal Metrics

For Authors

- Submit an article
- Calls for Papers
- Author Guidelines
- Publicity

        - Deceased Authors
        - Author Roles
- Peer Review Process
- Open Research Policy
- Artificial Intelligence (AI) Policy
- Statistical Analysis Guidelines
- Field Stations, Marine Laboratories (FSMLs), and Related Research Institutions
- Order of Manuscript and Supporting Information Components
- General Page Formatting
- Allowable File Formats
    - Main Document
    - Figures
    - Supporting Information
        - Appendices
        - Multimedia Files (Video and Audio)
- Detailed Formatting and Content Guidelines
    - Manuscript Title Page
        - Title
        - Author List
    - Abstract
        - Abstract Restrictions
        - Abstracts in Additional Languages
    - Key Words/Phrases
    - Equations
    - SI Units
    - Backmatter
        - Acknowledgments
            - Funding Source Acknowledgments
        - Author Contributions
    - References
        - General Formatting
        - What is Allowed as a Citation?
        - Personal and Public Communications
    - Tables
        - General Information
        - Table Components and Format
    - Figures
        - General Information
        - Figure Captions
        - Naming and Journal Style Conventions
        - General Appearance
        - Size and Proportion
- Supporting Information: Format and Citation
    - Appendices







Stay Connected

- Follow ESA on Bluesky
- Facebook
- LinkedIn

        - General Guidelines for Formatting Appendices
        - Naming Conventions for Appendices
    - Multimedia Files
- ESA Code of Ethics
- Legally Protected Species and Animal Welfare Certifications
- Preprint Policy
- Permissions
    - Guidelines for Submissions
        - Photographs and Illustrations
        - Including Previously Published Material in a Submission
    - Reusing Material Published in ESA Journals
        - Reuse of Published Figures, Tables, and Text Excerpts
- Licensing and Publication Fees
    - Licensing
    - Publication Fees
        - Open Access
        - Data Repository Fees
- Promoting Your Paper
- Editorial Queries and Contact Information

General Information

The following should be considered the guide for all stages (initial submission, revision, resubmission, and accepted manuscripts) for *Ecosphere*. Please refer to the journal's **aims and scope** before submission.

Please note that while some of the more detailed formatting aspects do not necessarily need to be implemented for the initial submission, we strongly encourage you to follow these guidelines from the outset, allowing for a more streamlined process for all.

- As an author, you'll have fewer edits at later stages.
- For the journal's editorial staff, having all material in a consistent format allows for straightforward processing.
- For journal editors, receiving a manuscript formatted for

ECOLOGICAL SOCIETY OF A

Assistant Professor, Biology
Indianapolis, Indiana
Employer: Butler University

Cluster hire in AI for
Saint Louis, Missouri
Employer: Washington

Assistant Professor of Animal
Fairbanks, Alaska
Employer: University of Alaska F

Associate Director of
Davis, California
Employer: Oiled Wildlife Care

For Authors

- Submit an article
- Calls for Papers
- Author Guidelines
- Publicity

For Readers

- Browse All Issues

our journals conveys the author has a strong desire to publish in this journal.
- For peer reviewers, receiving clean and well-organized material allows them to focus on the scientific content.

For initial submissions, it is imperative that the following requirements are met:

- Continuous line numbering is included on all pages of the manuscript.
- Both the manuscript title and author list match between the manuscript and the ScholarOne online submission form, as well as all supporting information files.

All revisions, resubmissions, and accepted manuscripts are expected to follow the complete formatting guidelines below. Authors may be contacted at any point during the submission process to fix formatting errors at the discretion of the journal's editorial staff. Please note that subject-matter editors (SME) and peer reviewers may not always review the formatting requirements for a manuscript; it is the author's responsibility to reconcile review comments against ESA's formatting guidelines.

Subject Tracks and Submission Types

Subject Tracks

In addition to general animal and plant ecology papers, those from all subdisciplines of ecological science, and interdisciplinary studies relating to ecology, *Ecosphere* welcomes papers within distinctive subject tracks (Freshwater Ecology, Agroecosystems, Disease Ecology, and many others).

Submitting your paper to a subject track allows the journal's editorial staff to quickly assign it to an associate editor-in-chief and, should the paper be accepted, publicize it along with other topically related papers.

Agroecosystems

Interdisciplinary research into the interface between agriculture and ecology. Of particular interest are intersections

of the four pillars of agriculture (production, transportation, nutrition, security) with ecological systems. Agroecosystems include managed forests, plantations and orchards, pastures, rangelands, and croplands, and the organisms living in them (cultivated and otherwise).

Animal Ecology

Research on terrestrial vertebrate and invertebrate ecology, including studies on population and community ecology, trophic interactions, behavior, biogeography and habitat relationships, ecophysiology, invasive species, wildlife management, and faunal responses to human development and climate change. We encourage research studies that develop new ecological theories involving the world's fauna, and/or extend and broaden the applications of ecological principles to understudied ecosystems and novel situations.

Climate Ecology

Research on current and future climatic effects on ecological systems, mitigation and adaptation of ecological systems to climate change, and sustainability of ecological systems under novel climates. Interdisciplinary studies are welcome, and spatial scales can extend from the individual plant or plot level to the globe.

Coastal and Marine Ecology

Research about ecological patterns and processes in coastal and marine ecosystems. The CME track publishes ecological science that contributes to ecological theory, bodies of empirical knowledge, or methodology. Applied ecology examining the impacts of human activities in marine ecosystems and focused on marine environmental problem solving in an ecological context is also strongly encouraged. Major advances in ecology will continue to emerge from interdisciplinary marine research that combines biological with physical science, natural with social science, surveys with experiments, and theory with empirical observations. Papers published in this track are quantitative and address questions of broad ecological relevance.

Disease Ecology

Research exploring the epidemiology, evolution, and ecology of host–pathogen and host–parasite interactions and disease. Outbreaks of infectious diseases are frequently caused by changes to the ecology of the host, the pathogen, or the environment. Therefore, understanding the incidence, prevalence, or timing of disease requires understanding ecological systems that support transmission and infection broadly across plants, non-human animals, and humans in both natural and built environments.

Eco-Education

Research related to teaching and learning about ecological concepts and practices. An understanding of ecology is crucial both for informed citizenship and the training of scientists. Thus, research into how people learn and apply ecological concepts is critical. Research can occur in both formal and informal education settings and can span age groups from elementary to adult learners.

Ecology of Critical Zones

Research that investigates the role of ecological processes in shaping the structure and function of the critical zone, the Earth's heterogeneous thin outer veneer extending from the top of the canopy to the base of weathered bedrock and sustains life through its provision of critical zone services such as climate regulation and water purification. Research that is interdisciplinary, especially incorporating geological perspectives and time scales into their studies. Possible topics include the role of plants in plumbing the critical zone, microbes in mediating weathering and other biogeochemical processes, and longer term geological processes in shaping the community and/or ecosystem structure and function.

Ecosphere Naturalist

This series is intended to attract a wide audience by showcasing the natural history of particular organisms (their morphology and behavior, their life histories, their habitats, and their roles in food webs and ecosystems). Submissions about animals, plants, fungi, or microorganisms are all

welcome. Submissions should include at least one striking, high-quality photo documenting some interesting or previously unknown aspect of an organism's life cycle or ecology.

Emerging Technologies

Research that uses a wide array of approaches and technologies to gather data, address ecological questions, or test hypotheses. “Technologies” include applications of machine learning; robotics and devices; integrated software solutions; and new developments or refinements in traditional technologies, statistical methods, simulation models, and image analysis.

Freshwater Ecology

Contributions that investigate the ecology of freshwater ecosystems, including lakes, streams and rivers, wetlands, springs, bogs, and ponds. We are interested in a wide variety of papers—basic to applied, genes to biomes, microbes to mammals—that are conducted in freshwater and rooted in ecological principles and theory. Interdisciplinary freshwater research is also encouraged.

Macrosystems Ecology

Macrosystems ecology examines ecological patterns, interactions, and feedbacks that occur across diverse spatial and temporal scales. This field considers how biological, geophysical, and social components interact to shape ecological patterns and processes. By offering new insights and predictive tools, macrosystems research advances general ecological theory and creates methods for scaling patterns and processes across local and large-scale systems.

Methods, Tools, and Technologies

Research in statistical theory, comparative analyses, and methodology applied to ecological problems. We are particularly interested in papers that compare different types of methods, such as manual approaches with sensor datasets. Papers submitted to this track will have less detail on the ecology of the system compared with traditional ecological

papers and more detail on the methods and approaches being used or compared.

Microbial Ecology

Research into the manner in which bacteria, archaea, eukarya, and/or viruses interact with their hosts and/or their environment. Hosts may include (non-human) animals, plants, and fungi. Environments span from ocean sediments to mountain peaks. Publications in this track describe how microbes can influence ecological processes such as dispersal, transmission, remediation, and stress tolerance. New methods are highlighted if they refer to data generation or analyses that emphasize ecology.

Socio-Ecological Systems

Research about integrated socio-ecological systems and the complex interactions between the ecological and human ("socio"- economic, social, political, institutional, and behavioral) aspects of the system. The SES track publishes interdisciplinary work coming from the ecological sciences that considers natural and social processes to be aspects of an integrated system. The track is also a venue for environmental social scientists who wish to share their research with the natural science community. Papers that push conceptual boundaries and build new analytical and theoretical frameworks are particularly encouraged.

Vegetation Ecology

Interdisciplinary research on patterns and processes of terrestrial plant communities and their interactions with the environment, including impacts and legacies from disturbances, either abiotic (such as wildfires) or biotic (such as insect outbreaks). Studies at all spatial and temporal scales are welcome, particularly those that combine empirical information with theoretical models. Of particular interest are papers that span observational data, field manipulations, and laboratory analyses, with the aim to provide an outlet where debate on fundamental assumptions is encouraged as long as it relies on evidence-based worldviews.

Submission Types

Article

Articles typically follow the format of a traditional research paper (Abstract, Introduction, Methods, Results, Discussion, Conclusions). Although there are no page limits, concise writing is expected.

Comment

A Comment points out errors of fact or interpretation in a paper that was previously published in *Ecosphere*. Although there are no page limits, concise writing is expected.

See the **guidelines for Comments (PDF)** for more information.

Reply

A Reply is a response to a Comment by the author of the manuscript upon which the Comment is based, by invitation of the editorial staff. In order to submit a Reply, this author must have previously submitted a signed review of the Comment. Although there are no page limits, concise writing is expected.

See the **guidelines for Replies (PDF)** for more information.

Concepts & Theory

These papers conceptually advance the field of ecology. They should go well beyond the works being reviewed to include discussion of new theories and conceptual frameworks that lead to new research directions and resolutions of old questions. These papers may be primarily conceptual, supported by published data, and without the presentation of new data.

Innovative Viewpoints

Innovative Viewpoints are thought-provoking papers that advocate important future directions, new ideas, or emerging frameworks. Viewpoints can also revisit historic ideas with a modern twist. Novel, cutting-edge linkages between ecology

and other disciplines that have the potential to transform science or impact policy are encouraged.

Additional Requirements

Papers submitted as Innovative Viewpoints should be defended with citations or data sufficient to warrant publication. Authors interested in submitting Innovative Viewpoints should first email a one-paragraph proposal (<300 words) to the **Editor-in-Chief** and the **journal's editorial staff**. All submissions will be peer reviewed and subject to the standard publication fee.

Synthesis & Integration

These papers are intended to provide a synthesis of a field/subfield AND an integration of those findings. These papers can begin by reviewing a topic, but they must go beyond the review to provide a new synthesis and blending of those ideas and data in new ways.

Special Features

Special Features are groups of papers intended to address various aspects of a theme that are likely to be of broad interest to ecologists. Ideally, the group of papers should teach a large audience about an unfamiliar topic or an area in which there has been considerable recent progress, or it should cause the audience to reexamine an issue that has not been settled as most have presumed. Proposals for Special Features should be addressed to the **Editor-in-Chief**.

There is essentially no limit to the topics for Special Features, so long as they fit within the broader scope and subject matter guidelines for *Ecosphere*. The key guideline is that the papers address aspects of a topic or theme and that this topic or theme is likely to be of broad interest to ecologists.

Special Feature submissions must be approved prior to manuscript submission. In ScholarOne, the appropriate Special Feature should be selected in the designated field.

For more information, see our complete **overview of Special Features (PDF)**.

Authorship List and Roles

Author List

All individuals in the author list must be entitled to authorship. Refer to the “Publication” section of the **ESA Code of Ethics** for guidelines on authorship.

Names of individuals entitled to authorship must appear in both the ScholarOne online submission form and on the title page of the manuscript, in the same order.

It is not appropriate to name multi-author collaborative and consortia groups as authors. If the entire group is entitled to authorship, every individual should be listed specifically.

Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools cannot be recognized as authors, as per the **AI Policy**.

Authors of Supporting Information

In most cases, any individual who contributed to supporting information is entitled to manuscript authorship and should be listed as an author on the main manuscript. Please verify this using the standard requirements for authorship of the main manuscript.

In rare cases, an item such as an audio or video file may have been prepared with the help of an individual not fully entitled to manuscript authorship. In such cases, that person must be specifically credited in the supporting information files. It is also customary to thank such individuals in the manuscript’s Acknowledgments.

Further, ESA requires a release letter from the individual who provided photographic, illustrative, or multimedia material to confirm their agreement that they are not entitled to authorship of the manuscript. This release letter should be given a descriptive name and uploaded with the designation "Additional File NOT for Review and NOT for Publication."

Deceased Authors

A deceased author must be entitled to authorship (see Authorship List and Roles: Author List, above) and must be clearly identified as deceased on the manuscript's title page. Copyright and licensing are considered personal property rights by law. It is our publisher's policy that if copyright transfer or licensing is not completed prior to an author's passing, affirmation of the deceased author's consent to be listed in the author byline must be supplied to ESA. This consent must be provided in writing. A copy of email correspondence will suffice.

Please provide an affirmation that includes the following:

i. the title of the manuscript;
ii. the names of all authors, identifying both the contact/corresponding author and deceased author;
iii. the statement of consent; and
iv. the complete name and contact information of the individual providing consent.

If the deceased coauthor provided consent to the corresponding author prior to passing, that documentation must be provided to ESA with the submission. If the deceased coauthor did not provide consent to the corresponding author, we require that the corresponding author provide documentation of consent from the deceased author's inheritor. If there is no inheritor who can consent, the corresponding author may instead provide a consent letter from the institutional department(s) that supported the deceased author during the period of time when the work presented in the manuscript was conducted.

For all scenarios, please provide documentation as soon as possible when consent is required. Consent documentation may be uploaded to the manuscript submission site with other manuscript documents (the file must be clearly named to indicate the file content and designated as "Additional File NOT for Review and NOT for Publication" in the file list). Documentation may be emailed to **the journal's editorial staff** at other manuscript stages.

Author Roles

The Corresponding Author is the author who will be responsible for all communications while the manuscript is undergoing peer review AND (if the manuscript is accepted)

production. During production, the Corresponding Author is responsible for completion of the licensing agreement, payment of the publication fee, and approval of the article proof. By default, the system assumes the Corresponding Author is the same as the Submitting Agent. However, if you wish that one of your coauthors fulfill this role instead, please make sure you have selected the correct coauthor as the Corresponding Author, by selecting "Assign as Corresponding Author" from the drop-down menu in the "Actions" column. Note, however, that only the Submitting Agent will have access to the paper in their Author Center for such things as submitting revised versions of the paper, while only the Corresponding Author will receive correspondence from the editorial office.

The Corresponding Author indicated on the title page of your manuscript will remain the contact for correspondence after publication of the paper, even if they are not the same author designated as Corresponding Author throughout peer review and the production process.

Peer Review Process

Manuscripts are processed and sent out for review using a standardized workflow. The following outline can be used to track the status of your manuscript. If you currently have a manuscript in peer review, you will see a status message on your Author Dashboard in ScholarOne under “Submitted Manuscripts.” All possible statuses can be found in **bold** below. For a more detailed description of the status of your manuscript, please find the appropriate step below.

The steps below begin after an author submits a manuscript via ScholarOne.

1. **Undergoing initial checking:** *Ecosphere* submissions are processed by the journal’s editorial staff before a preliminary evaluation by the Editor-in-Chief.
    i. The journal’s editorial staff check that the manuscript conforms to the journal’s formatting guidelines and editorial policies. Manuscripts are evaluated in the order in which they are received. After a manuscript is approved by the journal’s editorial staff, the manuscript will move to step 2.
2. **EIC (or associate editor-in-chief [AEIC] of a subject**

track) check: The EIC/AEIC will take one of the following actions following the evaluation performed in Step 1:
    i. Assign the manuscript to a Subject-matter Editor (SME)
    ii. Reject the manuscript without review (the manuscript will move to step 7)
    iii. Reject the manuscript and invite resubmission (the manuscript will move to step 7)
3. **SME check:** The SME evaluates the article and chooses one of the two actions below. The manuscript will enter this stage again if the SME has been asked to provide additional names of potential reviewers.
    i. Suggest potential reviewers
    ii. Make a decision on the paper without further review (the manuscript will move to step 7)
4. **Seeking reviewers:** The journal's editorial staff secures agreements to review. Most submissions are evaluated by two external, anonymous reviewers—sometimes more, sometimes fewer. On average, to secure two agreements to review, seven potential reviewers have to be invited. Sometimes the SME needs to provide additional names until the requisite number of reviewers are secured. If this happens, you will receive another notification telling you the SME has been asked to provide additional names of potential reviewers (i.e., the status will revert to "**SME check**" again).
5. **Awaiting reviews:** The required number of reviewers have been secured and they are actively reviewing the manuscript, with comments and a recommendation generally expected within three weeks of a reviewer accepting the invitation.
6. **Reviews in:** Once all reviewers have submitted their evaluations, the SME is prompted to make a decision. The SME will consider the reviews, and when they have decided how to proceed, they will draft a decision letter.
7. **Decision pending:** The decision letter drafted by the SME may include reviewer comments as appropriate and the SME may provide additional suggestions for revision. The decision letter draft is submitted for proofreading by the journal's editorial staff. Decisions letters are proofread in the order in which the decision was submitted.
8. The decision letter is proofread, finalized, and forwarded to the Corresponding Author. Decision categories at this stage are as follows.
    i. Accept

   ii. Revise
   iii. Reject with resubmission invited
   iv. Reject without option to resubmit
9. If the decision was “Revise,” upon receipt of the revision, the SME will evaluate the revised manuscript and either request further peer reviews (repeating steps 4–8 above) or make a decision (steps 7 and 8 above). Manuscripts that have received a decision of “reject with resubmission invited” are handled similarly.
10. The steps may be repeated as many times as necessary until a final accept or reject decision is rendered.

Open Research Policy

Authors are required to follow the guidelines defined in the **ESA Open Research Policy**. Please review the policy before preparing a manuscript for submission. Your Open Research statement should be prepared before starting the submission process and included on the title page of the manuscript. Please be prepared to copy your finalized Open Research statement into the corresponding section of the online submission form.

To further ESA’s commitment to Open Science and **FAIR** (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, and Reusable) principles, two Data Editors are available to guide authors and ensure compliance with ESA’s Open Research Policy. If you have any questions regarding how to meet data and code archiving policies while preparing your submission, please send an email to **esajournals@esa.org** and a Data Editor will respond.

Artificial Intelligence (AI) Policy

ESA Publications follow the **Committee on Publication Ethics (COPE)** position that artificial intelligence (AI) tools cannot be recognized as authors, as they cannot take responsibility for the submitted manuscript. If authors use AI tools such as ChatGPT or other large language models in the writing of a manuscript, in the production of images, or in the collection and analysis of data, they must transparently disclose how and which tool was used in the section of the manuscript to which use of AI pertains, with an additional disclosure statement in the paper’s Acknowledgments. In addition, this must be

disclosed in the manuscript submission form. Tools that are used to improve spelling, grammar, and general editing are excluded from the scope of these guidelines. Authors are responsible for all content generated by AI tools.

Statistical Analysis Guidelines

Please refer to the **ESA Guidelines for Statistical Analysis (PDF)** when writing your manuscript. This information is derived from the guidelines on "Statistical analysis and data presentation" prepared by the Statistical Ecology Section of the Ecological Society of America (ESA) in collaboration with the Editors-in-Chief of the ESA journals (May 2022).

Field Stations, Marine Laboratories (FSMLs), and Related Research Institutions

In recognition of the critical role that field stations, marine labs (FSMLs) and related research institutions and facilities serve in ecology, we ask that authors who have conducted research at or with the support of FSMLs provide the names and locations of FSMLs in both the Methods and Acknowledgments sections of the manuscript. By asking authors to standardize how they report the support provided by FSMLs, readers will more easily and accurately understand where data were collected.

Order of Manuscript and Supporting Information Components

All supported file types, including the Main Document, figures, and all supporting information files, will be automatically merged into one .pdf file (referred to as the “generated PDF”) in ScholarOne. This generated PDF is made available to the Editor-in-Chief, SME, and reviewers for peer review.

For manuscripts accepted for publication, the generated PDF is not used for typesetting and page composition.

Regardless of the number of files provided, assemble the parts

of the manuscript in the order listed below.

Items marked with "*" in the list below are required.

1. Title page (provided at the beginning of the Main Document file)*
    a. Journal name
    b. Manuscript type
        1. For *Ecosphere*, include the Subject Track if applicable.
    c. Manuscript title
    d. Author names for publication
    e. Affiliation(s) for each author that relate to the work presented (or independent researcher designation, if applicable)
        i. Include and denote each author's present address, if different.
    f. Corresponding author
        i. Clearly designate this author and include their email address.
    g. Open Research Statement
    h. Key words/phrases
2. Abstract*
    a. The abstract should begin on a new page, separate from the title page.
3. Text*
4. Acknowledgments
5. Author Contributions
6. Conflict of Interest Statement*
7. References*
8. Boxes (text only; no tabular information or graphics)
9. Tables
    a. Tables must be placed in the Main Document.
    b. Each table should begin on a new page.
10. Figure captions
    a. Figure captions should be grouped together and placed in their own section in the Main Document, preceding the first figure.
    b. Provide each caption a single time, in the location above, and no other location within the manuscript file.
11. Figures
    a. Each figure should be placed on its own page.
    b. Each figure should be labeled, i.e., Figure 1, Figure 2, etc.
    c. All panels of a figure must fit on the same page.

    d. Figures may be uploaded separately from the Main Document or contained within the Main Document if the quality is sufficient.
        i. Individual files should be clearly named (i.e., “Figure 1,” “Figure 2,” etc.).
12. Supporting Information (appendices, video files, audio files)
    a. Supporting information files should be uploaded separately from the Main Document.

General Page Formatting

- The manuscript text (including the abstract), References section, figure captions, and table captions/notes/footnotes must be double-spaced in 12-point Times New Roman font. Text in the body of tables can be reduced to 10-point Times New Roman if needed to fit in portrait orientation.
- Choose the "double-spacing" option for line spacing. Data in the body of tables can remain single-spaced.
- Each line of the manuscript must be numbered to facilitate the review process (starting after the title page and going through the end of the References section). Lines should be numbered continuously for the entire document.
- Number all pages (including table and figure pages), starting with the title page.
- Page size should be Letter 8½" by 11". Manuscript pages should be provided in portrait orientation.
- Leave a 1-inch (2.54-cm) margin on all sides of each page.
- Left-align the text. Do not justify.
- Appendices and other supporting information should be uploaded as files separate from the Main Document. See the “Supporting Information” section for information on formatting appendices and other supporting information.

Allowable File Formats

Main Document

- Word (.doc or .docx)

Whenever possible, prepare and submit manuscripts in Word format. Files prepared in Google Docs and other similar

programs do not always transfer to Word properly, and these manuscripts will require careful checks at each stage.

- PDF (only for manuscripts prepared in LaTeX)

If preparing your manuscript in LaTeX, please upload a PDF version as the Main Document file, with all source LaTeX files (fonts included, no T3 fonts) needed to create this PDF bundled in a compressed folder and designated as a “LaTeX File” in the file list. You can download a **formatting guide with tips for putting together a LaTeX document (PDF)**.

Figures

- JPG/JPEG, TIF, EPS, PS, PDF, AI are preferred
- DOC, DOCX, PPT, and PPTX are acceptable

Supporting Information

Appendices

- PDF (preferred)
- HTML (rare and should only be used when necessary for the content)

Authors can organize the appendices as they see fit, but they must follow our **appendix naming guidelines**.

Multimedia Files (Video and Audio)

- Common formats for video: .mpeg or .mov
- Common formats for audio: .wav or .mp3
- Metadata file: .pdf

Multimedia files do not have specific requirements for file types, but any files should be in a format that is easily playable by the average user.

Detailed Formatting and Content Guidelines

Manuscript Title Page

Title

- The title page should be included at the beginning of the Main Document file.
- The title may contain no more than 120 characters, including spaces. The title in your manuscript must match the title entered into the ScholarOne online submission form.
- If your title does not fit into the designated field in the online submission form, then you must shorten it to fit and update the manuscript to match.
- Titles must be composed in sentence-case, capitalizing only the first word and proper nouns. If a title includes a colon between phrases, the first word following the colon should be capitalized.
- A title may include a question mark, but never a period.
- Do not use dashes to separate a title with phrases. Use a colon (and use only one colon for a maximum of two phrases).
- As a general rule, do not use acronyms in the title. Exceptions may be granted for well-known and widely established acronyms (such as “NEON”).
- Do not use uncommon abbreviations in the title.
- Genus and species names should appear in *italics*. References to taxonomic authorities should not appear in the title.

Author List

- The author lists in the manuscript and online submission form must match, reflecting all authors in the same order in each location.
- Present the author names in a list. After each author name, use a superscript number to indicate the affiliation(s) for each author (see next point).
- For each author, give the relevant address(es) that supported the work, with each address given a superscript number that connects it to the appropriate author(s) in the author list. This is generally the institutional affiliation(s) of the author during the period when all or most of the research was done.
    - You must include the institutional affiliation department, institutional affiliation name, city, country regional division (for example: state, province, etc.), and country.

    - An author's present address, if different from their affiliation during the time the work reported in the manuscript was done, should appear with a "Present Address" label in a separate section on the title page.
- An author not affiliated with an institution, entity, or business should be listed as an Independent Researcher, with city, state/province, country.
- Do not repeat affiliations; instead, repeat affiliation numbers next to authors' names.
- Identify the corresponding author on the title page and include one email address. The corresponding author should match the entry in the online submission form. There can be only one corresponding author. See the "Author Roles" section for more information.
- The title page can include a brief authorship statement. This statement can cover information such as "Equal Contribution," "Authorship alphabetical," or similar. More detailed descriptions of author roles should be placed in an "Author Contributions" section.

Abstract

All standard manuscript types include an abstract. Abstracts are limited to 350 words.

Abstract Restrictions

- Citations and URLs should not be included in an abstract.
- Your abstract must be provided in English (see "Abstracts in Additional Languages," below).

Abstracts in Additional Languages

All submissions should be written in English; however, we also encourage authors to provide the abstract in their first language(s) or language(s) relevant to the country in which the research was conducted. These additional language abstracts will only be published online with the HTML version of the paper and will not be included in the typeset and paged PDF version. Please note that additional language abstracts will not be copyedited and will be published as provided by the authors. Authors who wish to take advantage of this option should provide their text in the "Main Document" below the

English-language version.

Key Words/Phrases

List a minimum of six and a maximum of 12 key words/phrases in a section on the title page.

Equations

- Do not include an equation in table or figure captions. Place the equation in the main text and refer the reader to equation in the text.
- In Word, display equations (those set off from the surrounding text with space above and below) must be formatted using Word's Equation Editor or MathType. Equations must not be presented as pictures.
- Use display equation format for equations containing characters with nested super- or subscripts.
- Equations containing stacked fractions should either be presented as display equations or, if left within a line of text, formatted using a solidus, /, and brackets, {[()]}, if necessary.

SI Units

Units should conform to the International System of Units (SI) per ESA journal style. This includes units within tables, text, and figures. If measurements were made in other units, those equivalents can follow the SI unit in parentheses.

Backmatter

Acknowledgments

An acknowledgments section is optional. If including this section, it must be a single paragraph and should appear at the end of the body of the text, before the References section.

Funding Source Acknowledgments

While funding details can be included in the Acknowledgments, please ensure all funding information is entered into the ScholarOne submission form. This information will be

extracted from the submission form for use in the final publication.

Author Contributions

A paragraph describing the contributions of each author may be placed before the References section.

References

General Formatting

- See the Wiley Journals Style Manual, section 3.2.1 for the style for in-text references to citations and section 3.3.8, Chicago Reference Style, for full citation style. Please note that final styling is applied by the publisher and that the final style used in publication deviates slightly from what many citation services will output as Chicago Style.
- All references must contain complete information.
- Each reference in the text must have a matching citation in the reference list and vice versa.
- Only references cited in the Main Document should appear in the References section in the Main Document. References cited only in an appendix should be listed in a References section within the appendix and not included in the References section in the Main Document.

What is Allowed as a Citation?

The References section of a manuscript may refer only to permanently archived material. If a reasonably diligent scholar 20 years in the future could not be assured of finding a particular source, it should not be listed in the References section. Some Internet sources have a short half-life; material should only be included as formal citations if there is reasonable expectation of future availability. As a general rule, any publication that has an ISSN or ISBN is acceptable but should be referenced by name (the URL may be added but is not essential).

Personal and Public Communications

Do not list abstracts or unpublished material (e.g., articles in

preparation or in review) in the References section. These materials may be listed in the text as personal observations (by an author of the present manuscript, with author noted), personal communications (information from others who are identified), public communications (information in published abstracts or information publicly distributed over the Internet but not permanently archived), or unpublished manuscript (with authors identified). Any references to unpublished data must comply with the **ESA Open Research Policy**.

The submitting author is expected to verify for all "personal communications" that the authority cited agrees to the use of their name. For public communications, the reference should include date printed or accessed, title of the source, and basic access information, such as URL.

Tables

The following guidelines ensure tables are formatted correctly.

General Information

- Tables must be placed in the Main Document, appearing in a separate section after the References section.
- Tables should be numbered in the order of their discussion in the text. Each table should begin on a new page.
- Tables must fit on a page in portrait orientation, widthwise.
- Manuscripts must have “true” tables in an editable format, created by using the “Insert Table” function, rather than using tabs or spaces and should not appear as “pictures” imported from another program.
    - In Microsoft Word, select “Insert,” “Table,” then specify the number of rows and columns and fill in the individual cells.

Table Components and Format

- Table captions should consist of one sentence that will appear above the body of the table. Rather than simply repeating the headings of columns and rows of the table, this caption should reveal the point of grouping certain data in the table. Statistical values and other pertinent details should be provided as notes/footnotes rather

than appearing in the table's caption. Please refer to the complete statistical analysis guidelines (PDF) for ESA publications.
- Additional details should be placed in footnotes and/or a Notes section presented at the bottom of the table.
- Abbreviations used in the body of the table should be identified in an Abbreviations section at the bottom of the table, in the order in which they appear in the table.
- Tables cannot contain colors, shading, or graphics. Use type style (italics, boldface, etc.) to convey meaning and identify the meaning in a Notes section at the bottom of the table (e.g., "Values in boldface indicate significant differences.")
- Tables must be presented in a grid format, with the same number of columns in each row and the same number of rows in each column, below the column headings. Columns should read fully down, and rows should read fully across.
- All columns and rows must have headings that identify the contents of the column or row.
- Subparts within the body of a table can be distinguished using (a), (b), etc., labeling and/or nested labeling within the left-most column.
- Table captions, notes, and footnotes must be double-spaced in 12-point Times New Roman font.
- The font size within the body of a table can be reduced to a minimum of 10-point Times New Roman if needed for the table to fit in portrait orientation.
- Table pages should be presented in portrait orientation.
- Tables must not extend to multiple pages in the horizontal direction but may extend in the vertical direction.

Figures

General Information

- Only one set of figures should be uploaded with each clearly labeled by figure number on the figure page itself and in the file name.
- We strongly discourage the use of images (e.g., photographs, icons, silhouettes, illustrative artwork) in figures beyond the data necessary to report your findings. The ESA editorial office reserves the right to remove any clipart/silhouette and/or require that the clipart/silhouette be replaced with a text label. Please

review our Permissions guidelines for details.

- Any figure containing photographic material or illustrations must include a credit identifying the photographer/artist in the corresponding figure caption.
    - Any photographs or illustrations appearing in a manuscript that were taken or produced by individuals who are not coauthors of the manuscript must be accompanied by confirmation of permission for use in the manuscript.
        - Acknowledgment of the photographer or illustrator should appear in the caption but is not sufficient for use.
        - Documentation of permission should be included as an “Additional file NOT for Review and NOT for Publication.”

Figure Captions

- Figure captions should be presented in a single continuous section in the Main Document, following the tables, beginning on a new page and preceding the first figure.
- Do not use the “Caption/Legend” or “Link text” fields in ScholarOne to convey captions (this feature does not work for all file types and can result in errors in the collated PDF generated by the system for reviewers and editors).

Naming and Journal Style Conventions

- Number each figure with Arabic numerals (1, 2, 3, etc.) in order of their citation in text. Label multipart figures with consecutive letters of the alphabet. Consistently label panels, using either uppercase or lowercase letters, throughout the group of figures.
- Whenever possible, all parts of a multi-part figure should fit on a single page.
- Define abbreviations in the figure caption, not on the figure itself.
- Symbol keys and scale bars should appear on the figure image, not in the figure caption.
- Label all figure axes and include units in the style “Thing measured (units)” (e.g., “Mass (g),” “Density (no. individuals/m^2)”). Units should conform to the International System of Units (SI) per journal style. If

measurements were made in other units, these may be included following the SI units in parentheses.

General Appearance

- Please use a colorblind-friendly palette.
- Grayscale patterns do not reproduce as well as solid colors or lines. Avoid small, dotted lines, thin lines, multiple levels of gray shading, and stippling. For bar graphs, use black, white, striped, hatched, or colored designs, but only if they are sufficiently widely spaced to appear distinct from one another.
- For symbols and lines, avoid very small sizes or line thicknesses (a 1-point width stroke or greater is preferable). All elements of a figure should appear with the same degree of intensity. If different degrees of intensity need to be conveyed, lines should differ by 1-point width for clarity.
- If no important information will be lost, consider placing fewer numbers on the axes to achieve an uncluttered look.
- Make figures as clean and uncluttered as possible; avoid extra gridlines and section boxes.
- Maps should include longitude and latitude, an indication of compass direction, a distance scale, and a thin outer line as a border. Make lines on maps bold and distinct while eliminating information not pertinent to the subject.
- Use black type rather than gray for lettering and scale numbers for readability.

Size and Proportion

- Images should be of adequate resolution (300–600 dpi).
- When possible, submit figures in the size intended for publication in the typeset PDF, using single-column width sizing of 8.5 cm for figures when possible. The maximum allowable size is 18 cm wide x 22 cm tall (to accommodate a caption underneath).
- All text must be sized between 6 and 10 points when the image is sized for publication.

Supporting Information: Format and Citation

Appendices and any multimedia files to be published with the

manuscript are designated as supporting information and must be provided with your original submission or revision for peer review and subject-matter editor approval. Any file provided as supporting information must be referenced in the body of the manuscript. New material cannot be added after acceptance of a manuscript. Supporting information should NOT be duplicated in an external repository.

When uploading an appendix, choose the designation "Supporting Information for review and publication." When uploading a multimedia file, choose the designation "Multimedia Supporting Information for review and publication."

****PLEASE NOTE: Data files can only be provided on external repositories. See our Open Research Policy instructions regarding data and code associated with submissions.****

Appendices

General Guidelines for Formatting Appendices

- Each appendix should be uploaded as a separate file, with all parts of an appendix merged into a single file, formatted as it is intended to appear if published. Appendices are not copyedited, assembled, or typeset by the journal's editorial staff or publisher staff.
    - When possible, a single appendix is preferred. Please do not upload multiple appendices that each contain a small number of items. In such cases, it is more appropriate to divide a single appendix into sections as needed.
- Do not upload any individual parts of appendices (e.g., figures and tables) as separate files.
- At the beginning of each appendix, include the list of authors, manuscript title, and journal name.
- Anyone that is listed as an author on an appendix must also be listed as an author of the manuscript.
- For each appendix, include a full References section for all references found within the appendix even if that results in duplication from the Main Document.
- We strongly discourage the use of images (e.g., photographs, icons, silhouettes, illustrative artwork) in figures in appendices beyond the data necessary to

report your findings. Please review our Permissions guidelines for details.

Naming Conventions for Appendices

- Appendices must follow the naming format “Appendix S1,” Appendix S2,” and so on.
- Within each appendix, the table, figure, section, and equation labels must use the format “S#”
    - Examples: “Table S1,” “Table S2,” “Figure S1,” “Section S1,” “Equation S1”
- Numbering is separate for each item type.
- Numbering of all items begins anew (with “S1”) within each appendix.
- For references within the main text to specific appendix items, provide the appendix label as well as the specific item label (e.g., “Appendix S1: Table S3,” “Appendix S2: Figure S1,” etc.).
- When labeling appendix sections, you can append text labels to the end of our naming format in the appendix (for example: Section S1: Methods), but the references in the text must use the format outlined below.

Please refer to the following examples:

Citation in manuscript	**Description**
Appendix S1	First appendix
Appendix S1: Figure S1	First figure in first appendix
Appendix S2: Table S1	First table in second appendix
Appendix S2: Section S2	Second section in second appendix
Appendix S1: Equation S1	First equation in first appendix

Multimedia files

Multimedia (video or audio) files can also be included as supporting information. If a multimedia file is too large to upload to ScholarOne, it should be made available in an appropriate online repository that assigns the material a DOI and provides reasonable guarantee of future availability.

- Each multimedia supporting information file should be accompanied by a separate metadata file.
- Each metadata file should include:
    - a header that includes the manuscript title, authors, and the journal name.
    - a descriptive caption for the multimedia file
    - a recorder/videographer credit
- Metadata files for video should follow the naming convention “Video_S#_Metadata,” with the number (“#”) matching the video file to which the metadata corresponds.
- Metadata files for audio should follow the naming convention “Audio_S#_Metadata,” with the number (“#”) matching the audio file to which the metadata corresponds.
- Any media appearing in a manuscript that were taken or produced by individuals who are not coauthors of the manuscript must be accompanied by confirmation of permission for use in the manuscript.
    - Acknowledgment of the creator should appear in the caption but is not sufficient for use.
    - Documentation of permission should be included as an “Additional file NOT for Review and NOT for Publication.”

Please refer to the following examples:

Citation in manuscript	**Description**
Video S1	First video file
Video S1 Metadata	Metadata for the first video file

Audio S2	Second audio file
Audio S2 Metadata	Metadata for the second audio file

ESA Code of Ethics

Before submitting your manuscript, you should review and ensure you adhere to the **ESA Code of Ethics** with regards to publishing. In addition, ESA publications staff and editors refer to **COPE guidelines** when applicable to resolve any issues that may arise during the peer review or publication process.

Legally Protected Species and Animal Welfare Certifications

Authors whose reported research involves species protected under relevant federal law (e.g., US Endangered Species Act, US Marine Mammal Protection Act) must certify that their research was conducted pursuant to applicable permits in compliance with the relevant laws.

Authors using experimental vertebrate animals must certify that their care was in accordance with institutional guidelines.

Preprint Policy

Authors interested in posting a copy of their manuscript to a preprint server must obey the following guidelines:

1. The version of the manuscript posted on the preprint server must be the original version submitted to the journal and cannot be any version improved by peer review.
2. If the manuscript is accepted, the author must provide a link to the published paper with the preprint posting.
3. Authors should disclose whether such a posting has been made at the time of submission in the “Dual Publication” field of the ScholarOne online submission

form.
4. Due to the nature of Comments, they cannot be posted on a preprint server.

Permissions

Guidelines for Submissions

Photographs and Illustrations

Images (e.g., photographs, icons, silhouettes, illustrative artwork) cannot be included in your article if their licensing is more restrictive than the open-access licensing under which the article will be published (CC BY 4.0). We strongly discourage the use of such images in figures in the main article and in appendices beyond the data necessary to report your findings. Use of images includes licensing implications that require additional verification before their use can be approved, and this slows the peer review and publication processes. If graphics beyond the data points are necessary, we suggest using only images created by authors of the paper, images fully in the public domain, or images created by an individual who has provided their permission for use in the paper and has affirmed their understanding that the open-access license applies to their material upon publication in this work. If using images, attribution and image source information must be provided in each figure caption. It is the author's responsibility to seek such permission and to follow any attribution requirements placed on the images from the source. Documentation to confirm licensing of public domain images or permission from an individual is required and should be clearly labeled as such and uploaded to ScholarOne, designated as an "Additional file NOT for Review and NOT for publication." The ESA editorial office reserves the right to remove any clipart/silhouette and/or require that the clipart/silhouette be replaced with a text label.

Including Previously Published Material in a Submission

ESA journals require that all submissions be original contributions, with full disclosure of any possible redundant publication accompanying the submission.

Reusing Published Items

Authors are responsible for obtaining permission to reproduce any previously published or copyrighted material included in their submission. Acknowledgment alone is not sufficient; authors must obtain permission to reuse material and provide documentation.

Permissions for reusing previously published items must be included with the initial submission. Documentation of permission should include a signed affirmation by the copyright owner of the material. This documentation should be included with the submission as an "Additional file NOT for Review and NOT for Publication."

What Constitutes "Prior Publication"?

Under certain circumstances, use of the same data in two or more publications is appropriate and beneficial. This may be particularly true when new information allows reinterpretation of previously published data. Although it is the Editors' responsibility to decide whether specific duplications are useful, these decisions are generally based on information supplied by the authors.

Sometimes it is difficult to assess whether a work has truly been published previously. If a previous work was published in a journal or book that is already available in libraries, or is available for libraries to purchase, we expect no more than one-third overlap between the previous publication and the new manuscript submission.

Reference should be made to any closely related previous publication(s), especially if a table or figure is reproduced. Authors are responsible for obtaining permission to reproduce previously published material.

Thesis or "Working Paper"

A posting of a manuscript or thesis on an author's personal or home institution's website or FTP site generally will not be considered previous publication. Similarly, posting of a "working paper" in an institutional repository is allowed so long as at least one author is affiliated with that institution.

Figures, Tables, and Text Excerpts

Authors must obtain permission to reuse any figure, table, or text excerpt of more than 250 words that has been previously published in another paper.

Previously Published Data

If any data in a manuscript have been included in other published manuscripts, the caption of each table or figure reporting such data must cite those manuscripts. Authors are also required to cite published data appropriately following the guidelines of the **ESA Open Research Policy**.

Disclosure of Overlap

At the time of submission, authors must provide information describing the extent to which data, text, or figures in the manuscript have been used in other papers that are published, in press, submitted, or soon to be submitted elsewhere. Authors should provide this information in the "Dual Publication" field of the ScholarOne online submission form.

In cases of overlap with other publications or submissions, authors should include copies of said papers with the current submission and explain their inclusion and the overlap in the cover letter. These copies should be designated as an "Additional File NOT for Review and NOT for Publication" in the file list.

Reusing Material Published in ESA Journals

Reuse of Published Figures, Tables, and Text Excerpts

All articles in *Ecosphere* are published open access under the terms of the **Creative Commons Attribution** License, which permits use, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, commercial and noncommercial, provided the original work is properly cited. There is no need to seek permission for reuse of any portion of an open-access article.

Licensing and Publication Fees

Licensing

Authors must sign a licensing/transfer agreement before publication. The author identified as the Corresponding Author will be contacted by the publisher shortly after their receipt of the final files and instructed to log into Wiley Author Services to complete the appropriate licensing/transfer agreement.

As a fully open access journal, authors sign a Creative Commons license and retain copyright.

Publication Fees

Authors of papers accepted for publication are responsible for publication charges.

Open Access

All papers are published open access and are subject to article publication charges (APCs). Upon submission of an article for consideration, authors agree that, if accepted, the Corresponding Author is responsible for arranging payment of the publication fee. If the Corresponding Author's institution, funder, or society has a **Wiley Open Access Account**, all or part of the APC may be covered. Eligibility is based on the submission date and organization having an active account/partnership arrangement when the article is ready to be published. After final files are conveyed to the publisher, the Corresponding Author will receive an email from Wiley Author Services. Authors may make a payment or connect the paper with a funder that covers payment.

For current pricing and other discounts offered by Wiley please visit the **publication charges summary** in Wiley's Author Services center.

Open Access Discount Codes

A discount is available for ESA members in the role of Corresponding Author; qualifying authors who are ESA members may find their discount code through the following